

real-time basis, you are a composer, an artist, a creative and investigative investor. That is what my father in his prime did best.

I went with my father about a jillion times to visit companies between 1972 and 1982. I worked for him for only a year, but we did lots of things together after that. In looking at companies, he always pre-pared questions in advance, typed on yellow pages with space in between so he could scribble notes. He always wanted to be prepared, and he wanted the company to know he was prepared so they would appreciate him. And he used the questions as a sort of outline of topics to be covered. It was also a great backup in case the conversation went cold, which occasionally it did. Then he could get things back on course instantly with one of his prepared questions. But his very best questions always popped out of his mind, unprepared, never having been written down in advance because they were the angle he picked up on the fly, as he heard an answer to a lesser question. Those creative questions were the art. It is what, in my mind, made his querying great.

His mind was financially facile until he was pretty darned old. I want to tell you about one of the best questions I never heard him use in person and only heard about later from James Michaels. It wasn't in his books, but it would have made a great addition anywhere.

A great honor of my life was that for fifteen years before his retirement I was edited personally in *Forbes* by the great James Walker Michaels, who at his retirement as editor of *Forbes* in 1998 was beyond doubt the dean of U.S. business journalism. He brought me into *Forbes*, took a personal interest in me, and edited virtually every column I wrote by himself (which is rare for a periodical editor) until his retirement as editor. He also admired my father greatly. Once, and only once, Jim and I had a reason to spend a weekend together on the West Coast, and he hoped to come a few hours early and sit down with my father, who then would have been just shy of eighty-nine.

They met for a few hours in a conference room at my firm's head-quarters on top of Kings Mountain, in California. Jim and I then drove north a few hours toward the Russian River and our destination; and en route Jim kept asking me about "that question." I had no clue what he was talking about, and I knew my father better than anyone in the world. It embarrassed me